

votes. Meanwhile, Dutt who won from the North West seat in 2004, thanks to the sizeable population of minorities in Bandra and Andheri, faces an uphill task this time. Due to delimitation, she's contesting from North Central. Unsure of the composition of her new seat and pitted against BJP candidate and eminent lawyer Mahesh Jethmalani, she's dependent on local Congress and NCP MLAs to build up a support base for her.

A major re-structuring has happened in the Mumbai North seat too which could affect Congress candidate Sanjay Nirupam's prospects. In 2004, Govinda defeated BJP veteran Ram Naik. However, Palghar, Vasai and Virar, from where the Congress got a good response, now fall into the newly carved-out Palghar constituency. And Govinda's lackadaisical attitude towards his constituency and absence from Parliament have alienated voters enough to benefit Naik.

Despite the anti-incumbency factor, the six Lok Sabha seats of Mumbai will not see a two-way contest between the Congress and saffron alliance. A spate of parties and their candidates are likely to spoil the show for incumbents and aspirants

MOHAN RAWALE, *Shiv Sena, Mumbai South*

A five-time MP, he has Sena strongholds like Parel and Lalbaug as part of his constituency, but lacks an agenda.



SHIRYA PATIL SHINDE

alike. While the PPI will contest in a few constituencies, the Samajwadi Party and the Bahujan Samaj Party will directly impact the margins of the Congress. But Raj Thackeray-led Maharashtra Navnirman Sena's (MNS) decision to field candidates in all six seats will cause the most damage to the Sena-BJP alliance. It will, however, be advantage MNS as their candidates

are former Shiv Sainiks and are likely to split the saffron vote. "A section of the Sena still looks at Raj Thackeray as its next leader. And after the Jet episode, MNS has got acceptance from the middle and educated classes as well, which might work in our favour," says Shirish Parkar, MNS candidate from Mumbai North.

With a multitude of new candidates, politicians are resorting to unique methods of campaigning. If Sena candidates like Mohan Rawale and Suresh Gambhir are focusing on 'corner meetings' to woo voters, others are using technology to connect with them. Deora has roped in students of South Mumbai colleges to canvass for him. As part of their summer project, they have to spread awareness about his 'achievements'. The MNS, which has recently lowered its Marathi pitch, is using Hindi-speaking party workers to bond with North Indians.

Despite the rather fluid political scenario in the Maximum City, there is no guarantee that the electorate will penalise non-performance because democracy in India is better defined by greed of the masses and fear of the minorities. Given that the voters find it difficult to overcome these two basic tenets when it comes to voting, Mumbai is unlikely to send credible representatives to Parliament. ■

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SANJAY NIRUPAM, *Congress, Mumbai North*

The Shiv Sainik-turned-Congressman carries the burden of his Congress predecessor and his North Indian origins.